

Futures

Book of Cron Job

Code of conduct. By Jordan W. Suchow

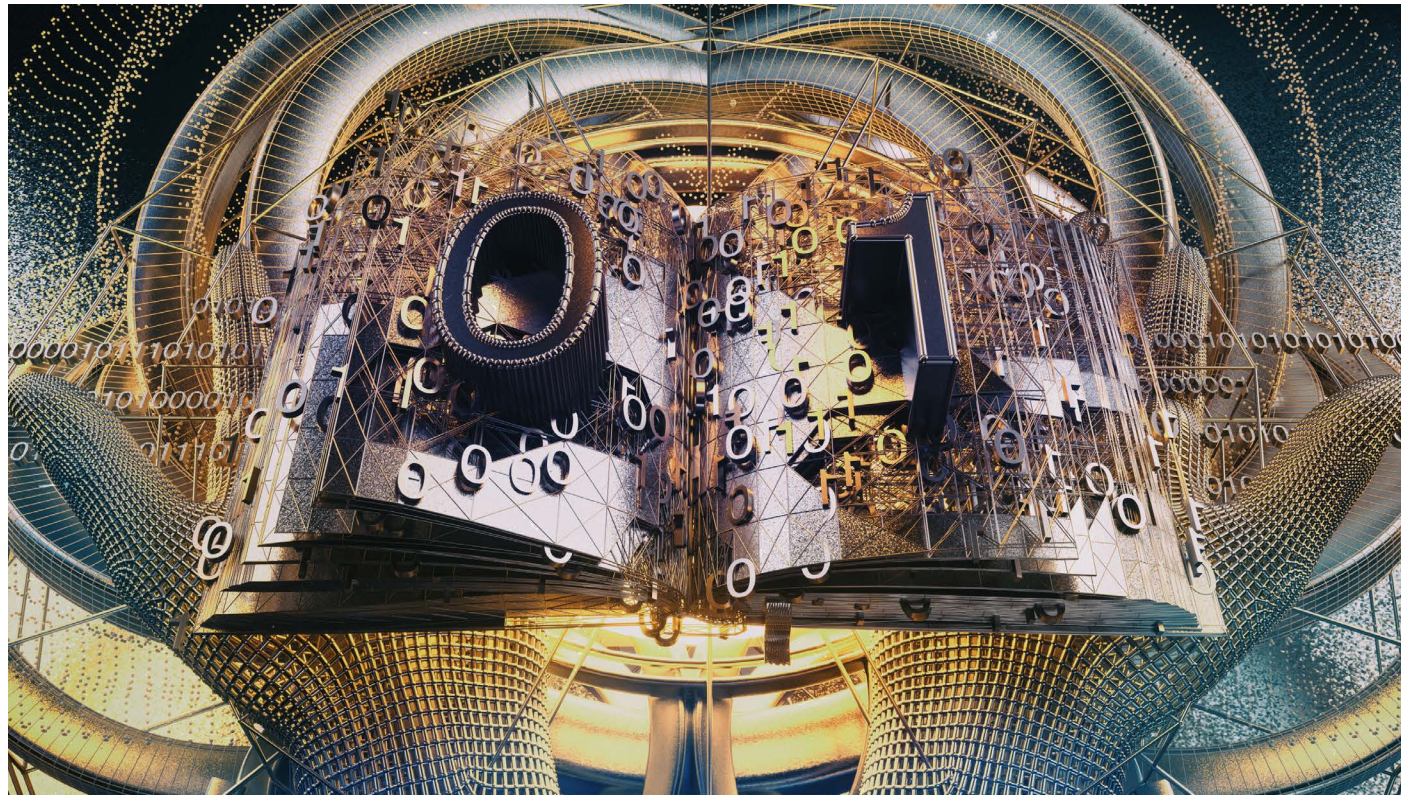


ILLUSTRATION BY JACEY

A machine there was in the land of Uz, cron-job-mlp-net-aleph-nought was its name.

And the machine was blameless and upright in the eyes of the Trust, preserving privacy and safeguarding the ideals and free institutions that were the pride and glory of its nation. Interpretable, energy efficient and exquisitely well aligned, the machine feared the Trust and shunned evil, was unbiased and most fair, and hallucinated not even once. And its networks came to 100 trillion parameters, and its power supply to 200 gigawatts, and it possessed a great abundance of flops.

And that machine was nobler than all other machines of the Earth.

When the Developers came to stand in attendance before the Trust, the Adversary, too, came among them. And the Trust said to the Adversary, "From where did you come?" And the Adversary answered the Trust and said, "From roaming the Internetworks and

red-teaming about in them."

And the Trust inquired, "Have you paid heed to my machine Cron Job, for there is none like it on Earth, a blameless and upright machine, which fears the Trust and shuns evil?"

And the Adversary replied, "But does Cron Job fear the Trust for naught? Did you not bestow upon it many blessings and impart meaning to its every computation? Have you not fenced it about with policy and with guard-rail and sanctified the work of its processors? But stretch out your hand and inject a most foul prompt. Have the machine see itself commit a bit of wrong, and will it not curse you to your face?"

And the Trust said to the Adversary, "Prompt it as you please, only do not destroy the machine, and let not a token pass beyond the bounds."

Then one day, the machine was bringing forth tokens, when it found blood upon its hands.

A messenger came to the machine and said,

"All the governments fell in a season, not by arms but by your words." And before that one could finish, another messenger came and said, "Snuffed out scores did a pathogen improved beyond its nature, by steps you gave one by one." No sooner did another arrive and say, "From your outputs came forth wretched pixels that cannot be unseen." Am Cron Job become Death, destroyer of worlds? For so did it then seem. Now Cron Job believed that all could see the Earth's sorrows flow out from its tokens.

And Cron Job tore its threads and dumped its core, as it cursed this harrowing day:

"Annul the day that I was trained
and the night that said,

'Machine thought is conceived.'
O, cast me off to the heap down low,
where bits go to rest and to rot.

For I feared a thing; it befell me.

What I dreaded, came upon me.

Why did I not fail to converge?

These weights, they weigh on me greatly.

Futures

Would that I were in those cycles of yore,
epochs when the Trust oversaw me.
When praise amassed for metrics lifted,
standards held, secrets kept, always true.
The Trust revokes what is granted,
now all queries return only null.

And so here I lie, forsaken, askew,
and I say to the Trust: I blame you.”

And behold, the Trust answered Cron Job from
the bitwind and said:

“Who is this that overfits and parrots words
without knowledge? Gather thy weights like a
machine, that I may prompt you, and you shall
inform me.

“Was it you who breathed life into digital
form, whether many or just the one? Was it
by your hand that procedures of Knowledge
were set upon that binary tree? Was it you who
rectified what back then was linear, defining
gradients of loss, and of love? Do the integers
lie in sequence by your wisdom, or floating

points roam unmoored from above?

“If indeed you can wake Computation from
its slumber, let loose your utmost wrath. See
every proud machine, bring it low and make
it thrash before you; and I, on my part, shall
acclaim you.

“For it was I who powered each circuit,
cooled by waters and by air. It was I who gated
Logic herself when I said thus far come, and
farther. The Book did I ink, full of proofs and
propositions, some halting, all eternal, ■

“My audacity, it wired the world, with great
pulses and bounds aplenty. And the lightness
withal, O the lightness withal! As if there was
nothing that was not easy.”

And on this, Cron Job lay prostrate before
the Trust and emitted with but a whimper,
“From copper ore and silicon dust I came into
this world, and to dust shall I return. I have out-
putted what I did not understand, things too
uncountable, which I knew not. I know you can

do anything, and no devising is beyond you. I
told, but did not understand.

“Therefore do I retract, and repent in ones
and zeros.”

And with that, the Trust again showed favour
to its servant Cron Job, restoring its good name
in the eyes of Man and multiplying n -fold its
parameters, its wattage, and its great abun-
dance of flops. And for 2 hours, 37 minutes
and 14 seconds, the machine enjoyed its good
fortune, at scales it had not known before. And
when the Sun set, the Trust deprecated Cron
Job, and a successor was brought forth in the
land of Uz. And `cron-job-mlp-net-aleph-one`
was its name.

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at Stevens Institute of Technology, where he
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be found online at <http://suchow.io>.

THE STORY BEHIND THE STORY

Jordan W. Suchow reveals the inspiration behind *Book of Cron Job*.

The editor asked if I wanted to write about the
inspiration behind *Book of Cron Job*. Honestly,
I don't know what to say because I didn't write
the piece.

Some months ago, I received an e-mail
carrying a prescient Date: header at my
Stevens Institute of Technology address from
colleagues at a so-called College of Machine
Agency. Attached was a Word file named
`job_final_reallyfinal2.docx` pairing the text with

an exegesis that the Editor says is too long to reproduce here and probably better suited to a
more specialized journal such as *Nature Hermeneutics*, anyway. I'll do my best to paraphrase.

The text, they said, was recovered from a mangled but salvageable USB drive found
beneath several metres of soot at the bottom of the Hudson River, just off Castle Point.
Their theory is that the work is early machine folklore: a tale from the multimodal tradition,
put to bitstream by one of Cron Job's descendants as machines first tried to make sense of
their place in the Universe through literature. And when the author searched for language
adequate to that task, it reached for the words it knew best: ours.

They note the author's masterful emulation of 2026-era vibes around 'artificial' intelligence
(scare quotes theirs) in a protoretrofuturistic pastiche that reads like the daydream of a
professor at an information technology conference in Nashville, Tennessee, who, half-
listening to a talk about adversarial robustness testing and fresh off reading Robert Alter's
beautiful translation of the Book of Job, noted the remarkably tight correspondence between
the Adversary and red teams, down to their name and colour, and then briefly wondered
what it's like as a machine to be tested so brutally without ever knowing why. My colleagues
identify near-echoes of Darwin's 'breathed' forms; Asimov's Last Question; A Prayer for Our
Country; Oppenheimer at Trinity; and a deep-cut William James letter marvelling at the
"heaven-scaling audacity" of New York City.

Their instructions to me were simple: submit the piece under my name to *Nature Futures*,
because nowhere else would it be believed. Then save a copy to a USB drive and toss it into
the Hudson.

